# Advisor Intelligence Brief

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## 1. Advisor snapshot

An independent, tax-forward retirement income planner with 33 years in financial services, running a three-company family office in Fort Collins.

- **Background:** Double major in construction and finance; originally planned to be a commercial developer.
- **Experience:** 33 years in financial planning; lifelong business owner who has bought and sold several businesses; long-time landlord.
- **Primary focus:** Retirement income planning for people nearing or newly in retirement.
- **Current clients:** Mostly engineers and science/technical professionals, ages 60 to 68, with $1M to $4M in IRAs and 401(k)s.
- **Key credential:** RICP (Retirement Income Certified Professional), The American College.
- **Practice structure ("family office"):**
  - Balanced Financial: insurance and legacy work (wills, living trusts, powers of attorney)
  - Fort Collins Tax Advisory Group, LLC: tax preparation and tax advising
  - Balanced Wealth Partners: RIA handling investments
- **Current production:** About $26 million in new money per year.
- **Reputation:** About 95 Google reviews over the last 10 years, which the advisor describes as very strong.

## 2. Origin story

A tax law change redirected the advisor's career before it started.

- Trained to become a commercial real estate developer (construction and finance degrees).
- At graduation, a new tax law made construction and development "a ghost town," so he moved into the then-new field of financial planning.
- He went on to earn several degrees and certifications in planning.

- His years as a landlord and business owner shape how he talks with real estate investors and owners.

**Needs clarification:** which tax law, and the year he entered planning (33 years ago suggests about 1993).

## 3. Expertise

Income planning is the center of the work, supported by in-house tax, estate and investment capabilities.

- **Retirement income planning:** Recreating $200K to $300K of annual income that lasts for both spouses; sequence-of-returns risk; shifting portfolios from accumulation to distribution.
- **Tax planning:** Roth conversions and future tax strategy, backed by a sister tax practice.
- **Estate and legacy:** Living trusts and powers of attorney, featured prominently on the website.
- **Business exit planning:** Three-to-five-year plans covering succession, how to market a business confidentially, transition risk and tax impact.
- **Equity compensation:** When to exercise restricted stock grants and how to plan the taxes.
- **Long-term care and Social Security** planning.
- **Real estate:** Comfortable advising on rentals, partnerships, and selling rental property to fund retirement income.

## 4. Credibility assets

- **RICP:** Comprehensive retirement-income program covering Social Security, military and railroad benefits, long-term care, and income design. Much of it involved critiquing PhD research on distribution-phase investing. The advisor relies on it most but is unsure clients recognize it.
- **33 years and several market cycles.**
- **Degrees in construction and finance**, plus several planning certifications (not all named).
- **Lifelong business owner** who has bought and sold businesses and seen partnerships survive deaths, lawsuits and reversals.
- **Long-time landlord.**

- **About 95 Google reviews** over 10 years.
- **Independence:** Not affiliated with any brand-name financial firm.

## 5. Best-fit clients

The advisor's sweet spot is decisive, data-driven savers moving from paycheck to portfolio income.

- **Serves well today:** Engineers and science/technical professionals, 60 to 68, with $1M to $4M in retirement accounts, wanting $200K to $300K of annual income.
- **Favorite traits:** "Two plus two equals four" thinkers who can make decisions, want clear advice and a high-probability plan, and aren't trying to beat the market.
- **Wants more of:** Lifelong employees from industry or government who saved well and want to enter the distribution phase with confidence.
- **Wants to move up to:** $5M to $10M net-worth households as the norm, versus today's typical $500K to $2M in assets.

**Observation:** The client he enjoys most (the steady employee) and the client he wants for growth (the $5M to $10M household, often a business owner) are not always the same person. Worth reconciling.

## 6. Client problems

### Financial

- Turning savings into reliable lifetime income
- Sequence-of-returns risk at retirement
- Roth conversions and future tax exposure
- Long-term care planning
- Missing wills, trusts and powers of attorney
- Equity compensation exercise timing and taxes
- Selling a business, and the tax and transition risk
- Converting rental real estate into income

### Emotional and decision-making

- A vague feeling of "do I have a plan?"
- Knowing there are things they don't know

- "Head trash" about retiring: uncertainty and worry
- Protecting a spouse after one of them dies
- Fatigue from managing rentals ("tenants and toilets")

## 7. Trigger events

- Approaching or entering retirement (the most common)
- A general sense of needing a plan
- Death, divorce or inheritance
- Restricted stock grants needing exercise and tax decisions
- Deciding to sell a business
- Wanting to exit landlording

## 8. Natural markets

- **Engineers and technical professionals** in a high-tech local economy (largest group)
- **High-tech employees with restricted stock**
- **Landlords and real estate investors** ready to sell rentals
- **Business owners** considering a sale or succession
- **Lifelong employees** of industry or government
- **Geography:** Fort Collins today; wants to serve clients nationwide virtually

**Stated boundary:** Faith is personally important, but the advisor keeps it entirely out of the practice so clients choose the firm for competence and trust alone. It is not a market to pursue.

## 9. Access advantages

- **Landlords:** As a long-time landlord with his own stories, he relates to them directly, and he welcomes real estate where product-driven firms see it as competition.
- **Business owners:** His own history of buying, selling and running businesses gives him peer credibility.
- **Engineers:** The local high-tech economy feeds a steady supply, and his numbers-first style suits them.

- **Tax clients:** The sister tax practice is a built-in source of planning relationships (observation; not discussed directly).

## 10. Success stories

| | Story 1: Repositioned before the 2022 drop | Story 2: Estate plan a year before a sudden death |
|---|---|---|
| **Problem** | A high-tech engineering couple near retirement in 2021, with 30 years of savings still positioned for growth. | A couple rolling over two 401(k)s with no wills or trusts, and adult sons with special needs. |
| **Insight** | The stock market helps in accumulation but can hurt in distribution; retirement income money shouldn't sit fully at risk. | A complex family with no documents was exposed if either spouse died unexpectedly. |
| **Action** | Moved a substantial portion into principal-protected instruments and built an income plan. | Completed the rollovers plus living trusts and powers of attorney. |
| **Result** | Months later the market fell about 22% in 2022; the clients were protected and grateful for the firm, specific advice. | One year and one day later, the husband died suddenly of an aneurysm. His wife could carry on with everything already in order. |

## 11. Advisor personality

Observations from the interview, not assessments:

- **Direct and practical:** Gives specific, emphatic recommendations rather than options to ponder.
- **Plain-spoken with memorable phrases:** "tenants and toilets," "head trash," "a path to run on," "no logo on my business card."
- **Realistic:** Openly says plans, products, companies and markets are imperfect, and values making "lemonade out of lemons."
- **Clear boundaries:** Keeps personal faith out of the business by design.
- **Builder's mindset:** Enjoys "the hunt" of marketing and growing the firm.

## 12. Strengths

1. Distribution-phase expertise grounded in RICP research (sequence risk, income design).
2. Integrated tax, estate and investment services under one roof.
3. Openness to real estate, backed by personal landlord experience.
4. Firsthand business-owner experience, including buying and selling businesses.
5. Independence and 33 years across multiple market cycles.

## 13. Weaknesses or constraints (advisor-stated)

- His own leadership is the bottleneck; he needs to move from serving clients to leading three businesses.
- Clientele is concentrated at $500K to $2M; reaching $5M to $10M households is not yet routine.
- Business-sale work arrives occasionally, not steadily.
- Unsure whether his main credential (RICP) carries weight with clients.

## 14. Business vision (three years out)

A nationally known small family office with a steady flow of pre-sold prospects, run by a team so the advisor works three days a week.

- **Clients:** 30 or more new clients a year; $5M to $10M households become the norm.
- **Assets:** Builds on about $26 million in new money a year (no target stated).
- **Team:** Three more employees, including a part- or full-time marketing hire for events, webinars and social media.
- **Lifestyle:** Working three days a week.
- **Reach:** Serving clients nationwide virtually, untethered from one location.
- **Positioning:** Known as a small family office covering financial, tax and legacy needs 360 degrees.
- **Ideal outcome:** Prospects arrive already knowing the firm, its track record and its reviews, and ready for advice on the next stage of life.

## 15. What excites them

- Clients' gratitude and relief once uncertainty is gone and they have "a path to run on."
- Fully addressing income, taxes, long-term care and legacy for a family.
- Marketing and finding new clients, which he calls "the hunt."

## 16. What they want less of

- Client reviews
- Asset reallocation
- Clients who second-guess a plan already in place

## 17. Growth obstacles

**Advisor-stated**

- His own leadership: shifting from client work to leading three businesses.
- Marketing upmarket to $5M to $10M households.
- No dedicated marketing staff yet.

**Strategic observations**

- Reviews and reallocations, the tasks he likes least, still appear to sit with him; they compete with time for leadership and marketing.
- The RICP and the family-office structure may be under-explained to prospects, since he isn't sure clients value the credential.
- Business-sale work depends on chance encounters rather than a defined referral channel.

## 18. Untapped opportunities

- **Business-sale advisory:** Wants to be the community's go-to office for owners selling or considering a sale. It fits his own history and the upmarket goal.
- **Landlord exit planning:** A repeatable process (sell rentals, fund an income plan) that few advisors offer.
- **Equity compensation:** Restricted stock planning for high-tech employees, an extension of the tax practice.
- **National virtual practice:** Delivering the family-office model beyond Fort Collins.

- **Reviews and stories:** About 95 reviews and strong client stories that could pre-educate prospects.

## 19. Differentiators

- **Independent:** "No one could put a logo on my business card," so he serves clients rather than a firm.
- **Real estate friendly:** Treats rentals and partnerships as part of the plan; most brand-name advisors see them as competition.
- **Three-company family office:** Tax preparation, estate documents and investments coordinated in one place.
- **RICP-backed income planning** rooted in distribution-phase research.
- **Owner and landlord experience:** He has done what many clients are trying to exit.
- **33 years of cycles:** Knows lifetime income is easy to describe and hard to build, and plans for what goes wrong.

## 20. Stories and marketing assets

- **Career pivot:** Trained as a developer; a tax law emptied the industry, so he became a planner.
- **No logo on the card:** An early-career rule that defines his independence.
- **Landlord stories:** Years of personal "tenants and toilets" experience.
- **2021 repositioning before the 2022 decline** (Story 1).
- **Estate plan one year before a sudden death** (Story 2).
- **Owner experience:** Buying and selling businesses; partnerships through deaths, lawsuits and reversals.
- **About 95 Google reviews.**

## 21. Strategic observations

These are observations, not decisions.

- **Top market opportunities:** business owners preparing to sell; landlords exiting rentals; engineers and lifelong employees nearing retirement (nationally).
- **Top differentiators:** independence; real estate friendliness; integrated tax-estate-investment family office.

- **Highest-value client problems:** reliable lifetime income; tax-efficient exits from businesses and rentals; protecting a surviving spouse and family.
- **Strongest story:** Estate documents completed one year and one day before a sudden death.
- **Most interesting untapped opportunity:** Becoming the go-to office for business sales.
- **Most important stated objective:** A steady flow of pre-educated prospects, with the advisor working three days a week.
- **Biggest apparent obstacle:** Leadership capacity, meaning moving client and service work off his desk.
- **Deserves deeper exploration:** Whether the upmarket push should lead with business owners and landlords, or with high-balance employees he enjoys most.

## 22. Open questions

- Which tax law ended the development path, and what year did he start in planning?
- What other degrees and certifications does he hold?
- Current total assets, client count and team size?
- Who are the three planned hires, beyond marketing?
- How many business-sale clients has he helped, and with what outcomes?
- Which referral sources (CPAs, attorneys, business brokers, realtors) exist today?
- Does the tax practice regularly feed the planning practice?

## What we learned about this advisor

He is a 33-year, independent, RICP-trained retirement income planner whose career began when a tax law redirected him from commercial development. He serves numbers-driven engineers and lifelong employees aged 60 to 68 with $1M to $4M saved, turning their savings into lasting, tax-efficient income. His three-company family office combines tax preparation, estate documents and investments, a breadth few independent advisors match. He is unusually comfortable with real estate and business ownership because he has lived both as a landlord and owner. Over three years he wants 30+ new clients a year, $5M to $10M households as the norm, a larger team and a three-day week. His biggest stated hurdle is his own shift from practitioner to leader. The clearest opportunities are business-sale planning, landlord exits and a national virtual practice built on his reviews and client stories.